LIFE ON BOARD

LIVING CONDITIONS

LIFE ON BOARD a warship has at times been compared unfavorably with life in prison—both involving large numbers of men confined in a very restricted space with no privacy and primitive facilities, but prison offering better chances of escape and less risk of death. In the age of galley warfare, although living conditions could be appalling in terms of sanitation and overcrowding, the problem was mitigated by the shortness of voyages and frequent landfall. But in the age of sail men would live on board for months at a time. To man their guns and handle their sails, the ships required large crews relative to their size. Work was hard, food often poor (though also poor ashore), and comforts few—a naval tradition maintained into the 20th century.



DITTY BOX Wooden boxes, such as this one, were part of every sailor's gear during both World Wars. They used them to store their personal possessions, such as photographs, letters, and wash kit.

SLEEPING CONDITIONS

Through most of history ships had few or no special spaces for the crew to sleep. On an ancient galley the density of crew and soldiers made it impossible to sleep on board with any comfort, and men slept ashore if they could. By the early modern period, with longer voyages in sailing ships, men usually slept on the deck on rolled-up bedding. Hammocks were a Native American invention encountered by European sailors at the end of the 15th century, although they were still not widely adopted on ships until the 17th century. Their many advantages, including comfort and ease of stowage, were eventually appreciated. On an 18th-century ship of the line men slept in hammocks slung from the roof of the gun deck. The hammock hooks were around 15 in (38 cm) apart, so in harbor the men's bodies were in contact while sleeping. At sea the situation was improved by the watch system, which meant that only half the crew was sleeping at the same time. Still, the state of the air in such a crowded, unventilated space, especially when in the tropics, can easily be imagined.



GUN-DECK ACCOMMODATION Space was at a premium in Napoleonic-era warships, so sailors slept in storable canvas hammocks among the cannon. Half worked while the others slept.

TUB This wooden tub, situated in the sick berth of an 18th-century ship of the line, was large enough for a man to bathe in.

FIGHTING DIRT

The need for cleanliness and hygiene was appreciated by navies in the age of sail. Sailors were required to keep themselves and their clothes clean, but this was hard to achieve. The use of the heads, opening over the sea, as toilets was strictly enforced, yet men, whether wilfully or accidentally, failed to reach them on many occasion. The shingle ballast in the bilges at the bottom of the hull collected detritus from the decks above, turning over time into a cesspool that infected the ship with stinking fumes. The substitution of iron pigs for shingle as ballast in the early 19th century largely solved this problem. Humidity was a plague below deck on wooden ships, with no sunlight to dry out the water that seeped in. Dampness was often worsened by the pursuit of cleanliness which led to the decks being over-frequently washed down.



SUBMARINE TOILET Underwater toilets had to be designed differently to prevent the external water pressure from flinging the contents right back. A flooded airlock ejected the waste safely.

